

Putting trust to the test: everyday negotiations of digital surveillance on TikTok

*Andreas Schellewald
Goldsmiths, University of London*

Digital ethnography of TikTok consumption

Methods



Digital fieldwork on
TikTok app (0.5 year)



Interviews with
TikTok users



Media mapping
techniques



Participant observation
of scrolling behaviour

Fieldwork



1.5 years of
fieldwork in
2020/21

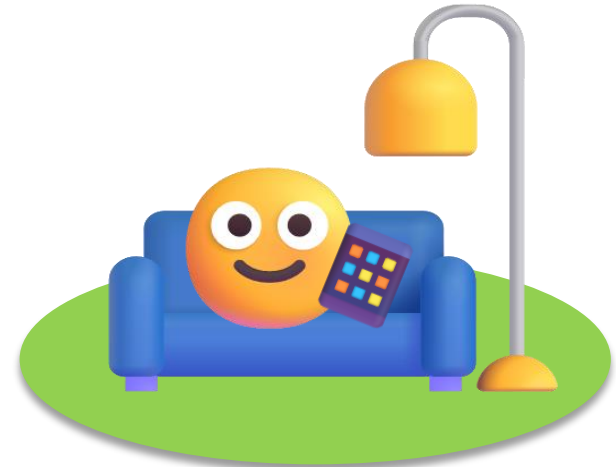
Working with group of
30 UK-based young
adults for 1 year



Trust in a social media (entertainment) context

- Sense of distrust in a social media context can have **chilling effects**, for instance, on meaningful self-expression online (Kappeler et al. 2023).
- Adjustments to behaviour due to senses of mistrust creates challenges for the **accuracy of recommendations**, further undermining outcomes (Cen et al. 2022).
- In other words, trust is a **precondition for** entertainment media like TikTok to afford a **meaningful leisure experience** such as when scrolling through content feeds.

"Entertainment is usually associated with simple, uncomplicated pleasure ... this is to evade the obligation to investigate which mechanisms lie at the basis of that pleasure" (Ang 1985: 19).



Taking some direction from the literature

- Trust as a form of **accepted vulnerability** to possible, yet not expected, negative outcomes in a relationship (Baier 1986).
- Moving beyond binarism (trust/distrust) and taking into account “**multiple factors that engender, maintain or undermine trust** in data-driven systems” (Steedman et al. 2020: 825)
- Analytical interest in the **consequences of judging trust** in a social media and algorithm context.

“To judge trustworthiness, we need to judge honesty, competence, and reliability. Honesty in claims and commitments made; Competence at relevant tasks; and Reliability in honesty and competence.” (O’Neill 2017: 2).

Honest?

Competent?

Reliable?

Worth it?



What trust meant in my participants' experience

Vulnerabilities

1. Wasting one's time



2. Data privacy risks



Trust matters

As a reflexive component, trust in algorithms to deliver, and comfort in one's ability to engage with them, mediated participant's ability to move through the digital space of TikTok.

Trustworthiness

Competence in delivery of expected experience

Reliability of algorithm as interaction partner

Honesty in truthfulness of "for you" claim

"When I do get my friends to join TikTok, they sometimes be like, 'oh ... I don't really like it. I'm not getting any good videos'. And I always say, 'just like the ones that you like and press not interested on the ones you don't because you will end up having the perfect For You page'" - (Joyce)

How trust was established

Considering multiple factors

 Negotiation of **digital corporate surveillance** : “TikTok is just like all the other apps, there’s nothing you can do”.

✓ Considering an app’s overall **status and reputation** : “It’s on the app store, so it seems at least somewhat legit”.

 Evaluation of risks in relation to **specific apps** and their particular uses: “I have more concerns about Google than TikTok”.

Conceptions of privacy

“The privacy thing I haven’t experienced because I don’t post anything on TikTok” - (Agatha)



Mediators

Educational background and interest in data topics



Prior experience dealing with digital platforms



How trust was put to the test



Vulnerability 1

Participants questioned their relationship with TikTok / the algorithm when it failed to deliver on the expected experience – when it showed **too many unspecific videos** on their feed.



Trust test

A trust test is a transgression from the accepted but unexpected vulnerabilities of boredom and data privacy, **disrupting the flow** experience of scrolling.



Vulnerability 2

Simultaneously, participants questioned their relationship when videos on their “For You” page were scarily accurate - when **content recommendations were too specific**.



An embodied experience, forcing people to reflect on the road ahead.

How trust was maintained

Multiple mechanisms

🔗 Although not always on their mind, the question of trustworthiness was always in (the back of) people's mind

💬 The TikTok algorithm, and its transgressions of being too (un)specific were actively discussed with peers.

📱 People drew on memes (like "FBI agent watching you") and other online discourses to make sense of surveillance.

"I try not to be too surprised but sometimes, yeah, it is like content seems very driven towards you or a situation you are going through. But yeah, I guess less so now because I've used it more and, I mean, I've liked so many videos. Whoever is in control can see exactly what I'm into. It's less surprising ... **but still weird. I'm still feeling like there is a spy in my phone** because videos can get very specific" - (Rhea)



Scrolling was marked by a latent sense of unease and feeling of powerlessness over surveillance

Trust as a mechanisms of negotiating data power



Further empirical evidence highlighting the multifaceted nature of trust (Steedman et al. 2020), the chilling effects of distrust (Kappeler et al. 2023), and the conditional form trust takes in relation to algorithmic systems (Wong et al. 2023).



Trust offers a **valuable perspective** for analysing power by highlighting accepted vulnerability (Baier 1986) and thus helping to understand how media are embedded in everyday life for meaning-making (Silverstone 1994).



Future research could further unpack the cultural contexts of judging, such as the cues that people seek in media to evaluate their trustworthiness (Arguedas et al. 2023), and the resources they draw on to deal with trust tests.



Empirical data highlights **trust as a key mediator of movement**, judged both reflexively and through embodied, affective experiences. As such, it is key for people to navigate online spaces meaningfully in everyday life.

Thanks!

Andreas Schellewald
Goldsmiths, University of London
andreas.schellewald@gold.ac.uk